

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Supply Chain and Logistics English

Conversation lab

Use these role cards to practice a response, handle a follow-up, and repeat with a new communication challenge.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

How to use the conversation lab

1. Read the shared case. Spend two minutes noting the facts and your first response.
2. Assign roles. The responding professional uses role A; the listener uses role B. Read your own role privately before you begin.
3. Speak for 45-60 seconds. The listener asks a follow-up instead of simply agreeing. Continue until the meaning and next action are clear.
4. Reveal the model response. Identify one useful expression and compare it with your own wording.
5. Switch roles. Use the second-round challenge and speak again with fewer notes.

If you are studying alone

Speak both roles aloud. Leave a pause after the question, then answer without looking at the model. You can also write a four-turn exchange and read it back for clarity.

Useful conversation repair

- Could you say that another way?
- When you say that, which part do you mean?
- Let me check that I understood correctly.
- I need a moment to separate what is confirmed from what is still unknown.

Feedback

Judge whether the listener understands the situation and can identify the next action or unresolved question. Correct one meaning issue and one useful language pattern, then repeat.

CONVERSATION 01

Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

SHARED CASE

A forecast exceeds actual demand for three months. Sales expects a new promotion to improve demand but has no order evidence yet.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The forecast has been above actual demand for three months. The promotion may change that pattern, but it is still an assumption. I'll separate confirmed orders from the promotional estimate.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 02

Procurement and Supplier Performance

SHARED CASE

A supplier acknowledges an order but gives no shipping date. The planning team needs a date to update its schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the planned ship date and any quantity that will remain outstanding? Please distinguish a confirmed commitment from a provisional estimate so we can update the schedule accurately.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 03

Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

SHARED CASE

A warehouse has high total inventory but repeated stockouts of two important items. A manager asks why the headline total looks healthy.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The total inventory value hides differences between items. We have stock in some products but shortages in two others. Let's review availability by item and expected demand.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 04

Warehousing and Fulfillment

SHARED CASE

A fulfillment team starts with 300 open orders and ships 220. Fifty new orders arrive during the shift.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

We shipped 220 orders, and 50 new orders arrived. The backlog is now 130 orders. I'll include both completed work and incoming demand so the change is clear.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 05

Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

SHARED CASE

A carrier estimates delivery on Wednesday but has not confirmed departure. A customer asks for a guaranteed arrival time.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Wednesday is the carrier's current estimate, not a confirmed arrival. Departure is still pending. I'll send the next update when the carrier confirms the shipment status.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 06

Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

SHARED CASE

A shipment file contains different product descriptions on the invoice and packing list. The broker requests clarification.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The descriptions do not match across the documents. Could the responsible team confirm the correct product details and provide consistent records for the broker's review?

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 07

Supply Risk and Business Continuity

SHARED CASE

One supplier has a shorter lead time; a second has available backup capacity. The team is considering supply continuity options.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The first supplier offers speed, while the second may provide backup capacity. Let's compare availability, qualification status, and switching constraints before treating either option as a complete continuity solution.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 08

Executive S&OP Decisions

SHARED CASE

Sales and operations propose different monthly plans. The meeting has ten minutes left and no agreed assumption about the promotion.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The unresolved assumption is promotional demand. Could we compare the two plans using the same assumption, then record the chosen plan, its owner, and the condition that would trigger a review?

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.